

going back on its words. Former chief ministers Siddhartha Shankar Ray and Jyoti Basu have been vocal against the way the case has been "handled" so far. The chief minister has removed four officers from the case and ordered a judicial probe but the Government is finding it increasingly difficult to justify itself.

Rahman had married Priyanka Todi, the daughter of Ashok Todi who owns the Rs 200-crore hosiery brand Lux Cozi, on August 18. She had then left her lavish Salt Lake home to slum it out at his lower middle-class Tiljala house. On September 1, a day after Priyanka went to Tiljala, Todi tried to persuade his daughter to come back. When she refused, he decided to ask some friends, who hold top posts in the administration, for help. On

TOUGH TIME: Bhattacharya on a visit to Rahman's house (right); protesters burn a police jeep



him. On a bond signed by her uncle Anil Saraogi, Priyanka returned to her parents' house on September 8. When she didn't come back, Waris asked Rahman to inform the media. Rahman, who had a lot of faith in the law, said he didn't want to sully Priyanka's parents' name. He needn't have worried. Todi, who started as a small trader, was allegedly involved in a cricket betting racket in the 1990s. No charges were pressed against him then. He is said to have funded Mukherjee's campaign when he was running for the post of the president of Cricket Association of Bengal last year. Bhattacharya had then supported his cause.

The chief minister, in these circumstances, finds himself under immense pressure, both from the public—outraged at the handling of the incident and the allegations of the involvement of the police—and from within, since the minority leaders of his party have to keep their Muslim

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September 21, when Rahman's body was found on the railway tracks near Dum Dum station, Mukherjee all too eagerly termed it a suicide. The condition of his body when it was found—in clean clothes with a single injury on his head—however, pointed to foul play.

Rehan Waris, one of Rahman's closest friends, is among those leading the candlelight vigil because he doesn't want to give up without a fight. Everyday, he finds more and more people joining in. "It's not just to do with Rahman, but my disgust with the system," says the 20-something radio jockey of an FM channel. Among the people who come to the vigil every night

are young playwrights, newspaper editors, actors and college students.

Waris recalls how an IPS officer, Ajoy Kumar, chief of Lalbazar's Detective Department, had summoned Rahman to inform him that there were two charges against him by the Todis—of kidnapping and abduction. He was harassed a number of times by the big shots of the police including Deputy Police Commissioner Gyanwant Singh. Kumar, acting at Mukherjee's behest, told Rahman to let Priyanka go to her parents for a week. "You are married. No one can stop you from being together," he had assured, saying that otherwise, he would have to arrest

votebank happy with panchayat elections due next year and the possibility of early general polls.

Senior CPI(M) leader, Mohammad Salim, for instance, has been quite vocal against the role of the police. "The police had undertaken a responsibility they are not being paid for," he quips, terming the whole incident as "tragic and shameful". He, however, fears that a political dimension to the incident will shift the focus from the real case. He feels that it is time for introspection. "We must address the larger issue of police behaviour. We need to change the system and sensitise the police force." The police force, however, has already been judged by the people they are supposed to protect, if not the judicial system, yet. ■